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ETHNOS

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INTRODUCTION

The following text addresses the power dynamics present in Participatory Design practices through the lens of the ethics of intervention. The main motif is seeing “local knowledge” and “normalized” power structures under the umbrella of research and intervention of anthropology, introducing and analyzing how ethnography design establishes new opportunities and cruxes in the future of certain communities. The last chapter of the text articulates a critical view on Participatory Design in the realm of Child Culture.

Key words: anthropology, ethics, Participatory Design, ethnography design, power dynamics, power structures, intervention, control, Child Culture

ARRANGEMENT ONE: ANTHROPOLOGIES OF DESIGN

"The old argument of design in nature, as given by Paley, which formerly seemed to me so conclusive, fails, now that the law of natural selection has been discovered. [. . .] There seems to be no more design in the variability of organic beings and in the action of natural selection, than in the course which the wind blows."

(Darwin, 1958)

Starting to have a look at what design implies on an etymological level, one can note an increasingly specifying scope of associations with significant shifts in meaning. In the 18th century, design is understood as "to draw for the purpose of construction", while in the following century, "to design" is rather referred to as an activity, establishing its own meaning in the same sense that we make use of the term today. (Murphy, 2016) Adrian Forty states that "the way things look is, in the broadest sense, the result of the conditions of their making", (1986) which one may unfold as under the umbrella of the same school of thought of Louis Sullivan's "form follows function", yet Forty brings us even closer to a less abstract idea of resources and contexts, as he directly mentions "conditions". In my opinion, the use of the word "conditions" relates the practice of design to tangible or defineable aspects and assets of a design process. Let us have a glance at architect Christopher Alexander's description of design, where he puts it as "the process of inventing physical things which display new physical order, organization, form, in response to function". (1964) In the same order of thought we can add Victor Papanek's take on design, "the conscious and intuitive effort to impose meaningful order". (1984) I stress the relationship between process, context, and resources to emphasize the probable clarity of a design recipe. People made use of design as an intrinsic strategy of provisioning for one another the conditions of life throughout history. (Murphy, 2016) Maybe the reason we try to dive into the etymological evolution and epistemological structure of design is to unravel what and when it "is" in order to address what and when it is or it is not "good". Design objects, technologies, and spaces are beneficial to both users and society in the sense of an orthodox understanding of "good design". (Hayward, 1998) Design can, at the same time, be looked at with a critical and somewhat pessimistic view, "an intrinsically wasteful endeavor", (Bauman, 2004) that overproduces goods, manufactures desires, and harms the health and well-being of individuals and communities. (Murphy, 2016)

Since we take the route of exploring what and when "good design" is, we may also unpick first what "good" means in a broader sense, disregarded of the motif of this text so far. In A lecture on ethics' Wittgenstein (1965) writes:

Ethics is the enquiry into what is valuable, or, into what is really important, or I could have said Ethics is the enquiry into the meaning of life, or into what makes life worth living, or into the right way of living.

"Good" is, therefore, the product of the enquiry of valuable, important, and what makes life worth living. Thus, "good design" can be defined as a physical or systematical incentive that gives life meaning by adding value to it. "Phronesis is experience-based ethics, oriented towards action." (Ehn and Badham, 2002) I have brought up the last quote to separate the two experiences of design, the end result in the form of user experience, and the design process itself. "Good design" stands behind application of ethics within both phases of design. And coming back to the statement from the previous paragraph in order to merge it to the current observation, "good design" is defined by moral usage of resources, applied consensually and empathetically in accordance to the context, while having in mind the health and safety of both designers and communities of users.

ARRANGEMENT TWO: ANTHROPOLOGY FOR DESIGN

“Design ethnography”, as it was established in the 1990s, emerged as an interdisciplinary for accessing “what people do, what they say, and what they think”, (Salvador et al., 1999) beyond surveys and focus groups, allowing businesses to understand people as social beings inhabiting rich cultural worlds. (Murphy, 2016) Reshaping the concepts of “user” and “use” through theories of embodiment and interaction (Larsen and Have, 2012) as spanning across modes, materialities, and practices, (Drazin, 2013) in order to decolonize Euro-American design power structures. (Tunstall, 2013)

Power is tolerable if it masks a substantial part of itself.

(Foucault, 1979)

Another question arises in the realms of both institutionalized and community level power dynamics. Since power cannot be absent from the equation, what is the role of power and the best way to integrate it? As Foucault puts it, we should analyze power as a circulating factor instead of a chain structure of hierarchies and decisions, “power is employed through a net-like organization.” (1980) Power relies firstly on

Participatory Design concentrates on the relationship between current and future practice, in a matter of various perspectives and cases, in order to accommodate the well-being of different communities while building foundations for future use. (Robertson and Wagner, 2013) The balance between “the realm of making” and “the space of essential action” must be kept in order to assure the morality that does or does not stand in the design practice and the industry of making. (Jonas, 1984)

“infinitesimal” practices, which take place “on the fringes or at the micro-level of society.” (ibid.) Foucault addresses hegemonic and global forms of power from a psycho-analytical point of reference, introducing not only the institutionalized forms in which power depicts practice, but those that take place within simpler and more private interactions between actors.

ARRANGEMENT THREE: DESIGN FOR ANTHROPOLOGY

Design ethnography does not “recoil from direct intervention”, (Hunt, 2010) as it may be believed about the practice of ethnography, yet there is the counter-argument that ethnography, in itself, is inherently interventionist, just like designing. Design-influenced frameworks allow intervention and creativity within the ethnographic process. (Robertson and Wagner, 2013) As Gatt and Ingold put it, “an anthropology by means of design” (2013) serves the purpose of joining forces through expertise with the people that are being studied, creating opportunities for vaster expressions and solutions which emerge from the synergies of local and global knowledge. Future-oriented processes of improvisational creation stands as a result of conscious and collaborative production. (Robertson and Wagner, 2013)

Those people who have the greatest reason to challenge and confront power relations and structures are brought, or even bought, through the promise of development assistance, into the development process in ways that disempower them to challenge the prevailing hierarchies and inequalities in society, hence inclusionary control and the inducement of conformity. (Kothari, 2001)

Uma Kothari makes a point about people who have genuine interests and needs within the process of decision-making, that are often lacking the opportunities to express themselves, making their knowledge insignificant. (2001) Bringing this statement in the same melting pot with Foucault’s observation on power mentioned earlier, we may get a more concrete sense of the “faulty pipes” through which power is channeled within an ethnography design project, and how design power dynamics can mute especially those who yield the local knowledge we have been discussing just a few paragraphs before. “The production and representation of knowledge is inseparable from the exercise of power.” (Kothari, 2001)

ARRANGEMENT FOUR: DESIGN FOR CHILD CULTURE

Simply put, a residual category is that which is left over after a classification is built – 'none of the above' and 'not otherwise specified' are typical locutions. A system without the possibility to understand the history and sociology of its residual categories desiccates stories it already labels 'unknowable'.

(Star and Bowker, 2007)

Putting all of the above in relation to Child Culture as an anchor for representation in design anthropology, ethnography design, and Participatory Design, we can have a look at children and Child Culture as what is conserved in history through genuine, ethical, and engaged documentation, but also at the less fortunate, yet predictable and irremediable invisibility of "local" knowledge. How do we engage as designers, ethnographers, and anthropologists into the practices of children as to establish ethical encounters and processes of participation? We must find our position within these processes in such a manner so we avoid developing hierarchies and methods unworthy of trust, which may rather damage and disorient our involvement into creating better systems that allow future democratic intervention with clear purpos-

es and strategies for all actors. Assuring honest definition of roles while paying attention to children's needs in cause may help us counter-balance the control aspect in the intervention process, keeping us grounded into the parameters of frameworks that prioritize the well-being of participants and stake-holders.

Beyond the matter of our own particular roles within these creative situations, we must also consider the power dynamics that come among children themselves. Since we do not embody the relations of the participants in direct ways, it comes easily at hand to overlook them and to interpret their actions and expressions as normal, even when they might disadvantage certain actors. (Kothari, 2001) Yet finding the right balance between intervention and control appears yet again, in an even more confusing and counter-intuitive form, as we meet Woodhouse's paradox of Participatory Design: "the more 'participatory' the enquiry the more its outcome will mask the power structure of the community." (1998) Or as Cohen states, blurring the boundary through integration and community control, people get involved in the "control problem", (1985) therefore we must draw humane judgements in order to maintain the intervention safe and stable for everyone included. (or in some cases even those excluded, having in mind the nature of their exclusion and the reasons behind applying such decisions)

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